



YOGA
with kids

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Welcome to this yoga with kids guide. It is my hope that the images and ideas you find here help to create time for you to play and move with your children in a way that is also enjoyable and fun **for you**. After all, that's the whole point isn't it?

Yoga is an ancient practice that not only helps us to stretch and strengthen our bodies but also helps us to learn about ourselves. It gives us relaxation techniques and shows us how to better handle the stresses of life. Bringing yoga to our children, teaching them a practice that teaches how to connect mind, body and spirit, which is so important in a world that is becoming increasingly disconnected. (And if all else fails, teach them a fun game that gets them moving their bodies!)

I have organised the poses in alphabetical order so that you can also use them to teach letters or sounds, if you choose. I have also included rhymes, songs and games to go with each pose as a fun way to introduce the movement. (I couldn't help myself! I am an English teacher as well after all!)

Each pose shows Eamon doing his session, sometimes with assistance, sometimes without, as well as my own. Some poses are also shown modified with Roif or too are also practicing with a baby.

Remember to model and encourage listening to your body and moving carefully when practicing to avoid injury.

Most importantly, have fun. Life is far too precious to have anything else to not have fun on our mat.

Happ yoga-ing!

Namaste.

How to and tips

Practicing with a baby

Pose name and benefits

Rhymes and songs

Eamon demonstrating & how to support



Aeroplane Pose (Warrior III)

Strengthens shoulders, back, legs and ankles
Builds heat and strong core muscles
Helps to improve focus and concentration



Depending on their age, you'll need to start by supporting them heavily and slowly move away to help them to build their own balance.

How to
Bring the hands onto the hips.
Shift all of your weight into one foot.
Slowly lift your leg back to parallel whilst tipping the front of the body forward.
Keep the hips square to the floor.
You can release the hands forward or back to increase the intensity.

Tips

Use a wall or friend if you can't find balance
Use the standing leg if you need it!!!!



Fussy bub who won't be put down? Try holding them to your chest and gently tipping forward! Feel your core working to balance you!



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PRACTICING SAFELY

As with any physical activity, the risk of injury, especially so minor, is always present and can't be completely eliminated. If you, or your child, experiences any pain or discomfort, you should stop the practice immediately and seek medical advice. Before taking on a home practice, it is recommended that you get the all-clear from a medical practitioner to ensure you are fit and able to commence a new exercise regime.

That being said, yoga as a practice encourages a kindness and compassion towards the self at all times. You should move into each pose carefully and slowly, giving yourself time to connect mind and body, and help your child to do the same. Remind them to never force themselves into a pose and to stop if they feel discomfort.

It is particularly important to be mindful that children are naturally more flexible than adults and may not realise when they are over-exercising. Help them to build strength and to avoid going too deep into poses which may cause injury.

BENEFITS

There are far too many amazing benefits to list them all here in one short paragraph. As with anything you're doing, the best way to discover them all is to try for yourself. Your kids will be more willing participants if you lead the way and I guarantee you will find yoga transforms you in a more ways than one.

Yoga ;

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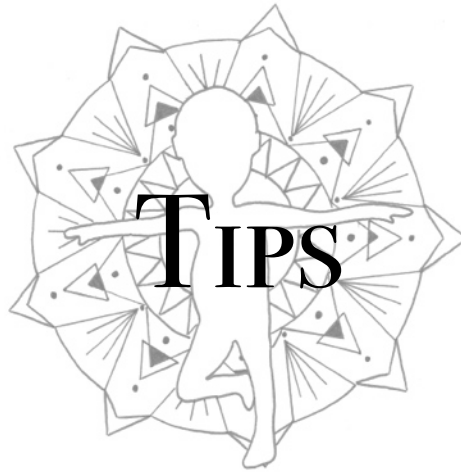
helps develop concentration and focus.

builds balance and coordination.

helps you to deal with stress and anxiety.

increases flexibility and builds strength.

builds confidence and self-esteem.



When practicing yoga, use the breath to keep focused. Give all the practice
 just breathing. He or she breathe in and out though the nose, gently concentrating
 the thought to create an oceanic sound on the exhale. Don't stress if you can't do this
 at first, just focus on breathing slowly and evenly.

Keep the practice short, especially initially. Young children will lose focus if you try
 to push them for too long.

Start with easy poses and build up to more challenging options.

Follow their lead. Most kids will naturally move this way and so get them to lead
 the yoga session.

Keep it fun (so they want to come back for more!)

Lead by example. Rather than trying to *teach them* what to do, just do it on
 practice and you will most likely find they automatically want to join in. (Much like
 everything else you want to do as a parent - like see in private!)

Don't worry about alignment or doing it correctly (unless of course the safety risk
 of hurting themselves.) Let them move in a way that is natural to them.

Remember the most important part of practicing yoga is simply being present. If
 your practice turns into lying on the mat telling stories for 10 minutes, so be it.

Turn off all distractions, except for music. You may like to play some background
 music to set the tone of the session (Eg. relaxing for goodnight yoga, fast paced to
 burn off excess energy)

Turn it into a game. Yoga with kids isn't just for exercise. Play games, sing songs,
 play guess the pose, make up your own poses and most importantly HAVE FUN!